PIANO BUTLER



Handbook

The language of music, from the whole to the detail

Reading, pitch, time, harmony, expression, form and history: every term and table a pianist needs, from the first lesson to Level 8.

PREPARED BY THE PIANO BUTLER · THEPIANOBUTLER.COM

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A map of music

Six parts, from the largest idea to the smallest detail. Read a part from the start for the whole picture, or go straight to the table you need.

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PART II

Time

Music moves through time. Underneath it runs a steady **pulse**; the pulse is grouped into **bars**; and every note and rest takes up a measured share of it. This part goes from that big picture down to the length of a single note.

1 **Pulse** — the steady beat underneath

›

2 **Bar** — beats grouped: 2, 3 or 4

›

3 **Time signature** — how many beats, and which note is one beat

›

4 **Note values** — how long each note lasts

›

5 **Rhythm** — the pattern of long and short

IN THIS PART

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PART II · TIME

Notes and rests

A note's shape shows how long it lasts. Each plain note lasts **half as long** as the one above it; a **dot** adds half the note's value again. Every note has a rest of the same length: a silence, counted just as carefully.

NOTE	REST	NAME	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		**breve**	**8**	Level 4
		**dotted semibreve**	**6**	*beyond Level 8*
		semibreve	**4**	Level 0
		**dotted minim**	**3**	Level 0
		**minim**	**2**	Level 0
		**dotted crotchet**	**1½**	Level ½
		**crotchet**	**1**	Level 0
		**dotted quaver**	**¾**	Level 3
		**quaver**	**½**	Level 0
		**semiquaver**	**¼**	Level 2
		**demisemiquaver**	**⅛**	*beyond Level 8*
		**hemidemisemiquaver**	**1/16**	*beyond Level 8*

* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4.

Groups of other sizes



Triplet: three notes in the time of two.
Level 2



Duplet: two notes in the time of three.
Level 3

See also

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Practise it

Workbook Level 0 · Note values
Online · Library › Notes and rests